The Gospel of Wealth

Andrew Carnegie · June 1889

Source: Andrew Carnegie, "The Gospel of Wealth" (1889). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> The steel magnate argued that great fortunes are inevitable and good, but that the rich hold their wealth as "trustees" morally bound to give it away for the public good in their own lifetimes — the founding creed of American philanthropy.

There are but three modes in which surplus wealth can be disposed of. It can be left to the families of the decedents; or it can be bequeathed for public purposes; or, finally, it can be administered during their lives by its possessors.

[. . .]

This, then, is held to be the duty of the man of Wealth: First, to set an example of modest, unostentatious living, shunning display or extravagance; to provide moderately for the legitimate wants of those dependent upon him; and after doing so to consider all surplus revenues which come to him simply as trust funds, which he is called upon to administer . . . the man of wealth thus becoming the mere agent and trustee for his poorer brethren, bringing to their service his superior wisdom, experience and ability to administer, doing for them better than they would or could do for themselves. . . . The man who dies leaving behind many millions of available wealth, which was his to administer during life, will pass away "unwept, unhonored, and unsung." . . . "The man who dies thus rich dies disgraced."